

FROM GLAMOUR TO UTILITY

The Wall Street Crash in the autumn of 1929 brought the Roaring Twenties to an abrupt halt. Hemlines dropped suddenly while waistlines rose to a little above the natural waist – the reign of the youthful flapper was truly over. "Austerity daywear" for women was angled and slim-fitting, with wide shoulder pads and calf-length skirts. During the day, the slimline silhouette was broken up and softened with clever seaming, belts, novelty buttons, deep cuffs, and pussy bows. In the evening, the focus shifted from legs to plunging backs with designers such as Lanvin, Mainbocher, and Chanel producing shimmering, floor-length dresses.

Fashion at the movies

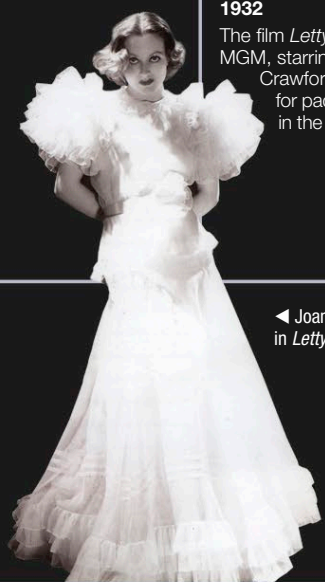
During the 1930s New York ready-to-wear designers developed a new style that seemed to embody the nation's values. Their practical approach resulted in easy-to-wear pieces that could be adapted to different occasions by mixing and matching. At the opposite end of the scale, Hollywood designers Adrian, Walter Plunket, and Travis Banton created glamorous outfits for stars such as Jean Harlow, Joan Crawford, and Marlene Dietrich. These Hollywood styles were arguably the biggest influence on fashion in the 1930s. Out of reach for most, patterns and pared-down versions were available for those of less lavish means. Hollywood stars Fred Astaire, Cary Grant, and Gary Cooper set impossibly high standards for male beauty and elegance. The look became a bestseller on both sides of the Atlantic, and many bought their suits in London's Savile Row.

Effects of the war

The start of World War II in 1939 brought an end to lavish, excessive designs. Many countries established a rationing system, trying to prevent the waste of scarce resources and ensure a fair distribution of garments. Decorative features such as excessive pleating and lace were abandoned, leading to simplified styles that constituted a kind of civilian uniform. Paris retained a skeletal couture industry after the invasion in 1940, but the rest of the world was cut off from French fashion dictates. New US fashions emerged and some hoped that French couture's sometimes excessive use of fabric and decorations had been banished forever, but this was not to be.



US WOMEN'S ARMY UNIFORMS, 1940s
Three women model, from left to right, officer's winter uniform, officer's summer uniform, and auxiliary private's uniform.

1929–30	1931–32	1933–34	
1930 As fashion becomes more conservative, dresses are generally styled with a lower hemline. ▼ Depression hits, hemlines fall		◀ Astaire's elegant style	
	1932 <i>Flying Down to Rio</i> pairs Fred Astaire and Ginger Rogers for the first time. Astaire was an impeccable dresser on and off the screen, favouring suits made in London's Savile Row.	1934 The word "brassiere" is gradually shortened to "bra" through the decade. According to a survey by <i>Harper's Bazaar</i>, "bra" is the most commonly used expression among college women for the brassiere.	
	1932 The film <i>Letty Lynton</i> by MGM, starring Joan Crawford, begins a craze for padded shoulders in the US. ◀ Joan Crawford in <i>Letty Lynton</i>	▼ First shorts at Wimbledon	